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“I would never change a Pro League title for a World Cup, European Cup or Olympics,” said Germany forward Christopher Ruhr, moments after his nation’s second successive world title in Wavre, a quiet town in Belgium.

A month earlier, however, Germany’s credentials to defend its

crown had been called into question owing to its poor Pro League form, where it finished sixth. Belgium, England, Netherlands, Australia and Argentina had all shown better form and were tipped among the favourites.

But Germany’s Pro League ranking did not necessarily reflect its ability to turn things around when it mattered most. Across six editions of the competition before 2025-26, it had never finished inside the top two, while finishing sixth three times. Yet, during that time, it had won the World Cup, reached an Olympic final and made two Euro finals, winning one. That’s the hallmark of a ‘tournament’ team.

The 2026 World Cup was all the more challenging, with the team undergoing significant transition. Only nine players from the 2023 title-winning squad and 11 from the 2025 EuroHockey Championship-winning squads were part of the group in the Netherlands and Belgium.

When the World Cup got underway, Germany’s collective spirit shone through in crucial moments. It once again embodied what Ruhr called the ‘German character’ to emerge champions once again.

In the Pro League, Germany had shipped nearly three goals per game. Despite its inexperienced defensive set-up, the Honamas tightened up at the back at the World Cup, conceding a tournament-best seven goals in seven matches.

Nothing would have given this side more vindication of its process than seeing three of its five junior World Cup-winning players contribute two goals apiece, including Michel Struthoff, who scored the decisive goal in an attritional final against Spain. With less than 20 minutes left, the 23-year-old kept his composure to round the ‘keeper and pass the ball



Most goals at FIH World Cup

Men

Tomas Domene (ARG) - 10 goals
Mustaphaa Cassiem (RSA) - 8 goals
Harmanpreet Singh (IND) - 8 goals
Jose Basterra (ESP) - 7 goals
Tom Boon (BEL) - 5 goals

Women

Yibbi Jansen (NED) - 8 goals
Marijn Veen (NED) - 5 goals
Charlotte Englebert (BEL) - 4 goals
Meirong Zou (CHN) - 4 goals
Navneet Kaur (IND) - 4 goals

into the net.

“I think we believed it more than the rest of the world did and that’s most important,” Ruhr reflected after the final.

This German team, under Andre Henning, once again proved that when it matters most, it always finds a way to win.

A different ending

If the men’s event had a wide pool of contenders for the title, in the women’s section, it was hard to look past the formidable Netherlands.

For close to a decade, the Dutch had known nothing but success. The last time Netherlands lost a major competition in a knockout tie was the 2016 Olympics final, with the team striking gold nine times since then. Playing in another home World Cup at Amstelveen’s Wagener Stadion, a cathedral of the sport, it seemed inevitable there would be another Oranje coronation at the culmination of the Dutch summer.

But when Argentina’s Sofia Cairo rounded Anne Veenendaal to score